

"Jumping Through Hoops to Exist": System-Involved Youth Navigating Resources in the Transition to Adulthood

Johanna Olesk
Department of Computer Science and
Engineering
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
jolesk@nd.edu

Cassandra Barco
Department of Computer Science and
Engineering
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
cbarco@nd.edu

Vishal Sharma
College of Engineering
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
vishal.sharma@nd.edu

Christian Farls
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
christianfarls5@gmail.com

Lindsay Roney
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
lindsayroney726@gmail.com

Kate Schinaman
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
kschinaman01@gmail.com

Samuel Sokolsky-Tifft
Institute for Social Concerns
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
ssokolsk@nd.edu

Karla Badillo-Urquiola
Department of Computer Science and
Engineering
University of Notre Dame
Notre Dame, Indiana, USA
kbadillou@nd.edu

Abstract

Youth transitioning out of foster care or the juvenile justice system require substantial preparation to achieve successful independent living. Although numerous services exist, they are unevenly distributed across jurisdictions and organizations, making them difficult for youth to discover and access, particularly after leaving the system. Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) researchers have studied technology-mediated social and emotional support for system-involved youth. Extending the scholarship, we examine informational support by conducting interviews with system-involved youth to examine their lived experiences navigating resources during and after transition. We find that challenges emerge primarily from systemic issues in resource distribution and communication, rather than from insufficient resources. Participants expressed a strong desire for a youth-centered space that supports personalized resource navigation and sustained connection with trusted support networks beyond system exit. Our poster outlines implications for developing more accessible information and support platforms for system-involved youth to help them successfully transition to adulthood.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

Keywords

Foster Care, Juvenile Justice System, System-involved Youth, Child Welfare, Informational Support

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1 Introduction

Every year in the U.S., over 15,000 children in foster care age out annually without reunification or adoption [13], while over 600,000 people are released from juvenile detention centers and prisons annually [24]. Youth who navigate these systems, also called *system-involved youth*¹, often transition from highly structured environments where housing, education, and support are institutionally mediated into a fragmented landscape where they must suddenly navigate complex resources alone. A variety of programs exists to support these transitions, including reentry services [2, 46, 47], workforce development programs [9], mentoring programs [37, 38, 41], and independent living services [22, 32]. Yet, these resources are unevenly distributed across institutions and local jurisdictions, leading to fragmented access [18, 33].

Within Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), researchers have examined how technology can facilitate social support for foster youth through a mobile application designed to foster belonging and peer connection [31], online communities [3, 19, 36], and by

¹Youth who have interacted with the child welfare (e.g., foster care), juvenile justice, or both.



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understanding foster youth's online experiences [5]. For example, Kumar et al. [31] collaborated with current and former foster youth to design a mobile application to increase social support not addressed by foster care services, such as increased feelings of belonging and motivation to pursue goals, and esteem support through peer interaction. Yet most research examining youth involved in juvenile justice has happened beyond the HCI community and focused primarily on mental health access [1, 29] and recidivism reduction through educational interventions [20, 34]. What remains underexplored is the *informational* dimension, i.e., how system-involved youth learn about, locate, and access the resources available to them and how digital tools might better support this process. Although researchers have begun documenting the extensive infrastructural labor that practitioners undertake to connect youth with fragmented services [49], few studies center youth themselves in identifying their informational needs or in designing systems to meet them [11, 21]. In this paper, we ask:

- **RQ1:** How did previous system-involved youth experience and navigate access to resources and support across the transition to independence?
- **RQ2:** How can digital tools address the informational needs of systems-involved youth?

We conducted semi-structured interviews with young adults in the U.S. Midwest (Indiana and Illinois) who have transitioned out of foster care (N=9) and juvenile justice (N=2) systems. We noted that the challenge lies less in the availability of resources and more in how they are distributed and communicated to system-involved youth. Youth described significant barriers to accessing resources, including limited communication from staff and a sudden loss of access to guiding resources after transitioning out. They expressed a desire for a youth-focused space that connects them to resources and to supportive relationships with mentors and peers. Based on these insights, we offer recommendations for designing centralized platforms tailored to these youth, providing comprehensive, up-to-date resources that are easy to navigate and incorporate relational and peer-based support through live chats and anonymous spaces for sharing experiences. In doing so, our poster makes the following contributions:

- While much HCI research on system-involved youth emphasizes social support [31, 36], we highlight the importance of designing for access to informational resources.
- We provide insights from system-involved youth, centering their voices and lived experiences to inform design.
- We offer design directions for HCI researchers to create tools that improve accessibility, organization, and communication of resources for system-involved youth.

2 Study Context

This study focuses on the foster care and juvenile justice systems due to their well-documented overlap, often described as the “foster care-to-prison pipeline” [6]. In the U.S., more than 30% of foster youth experience juvenile justice involvement before age 17, nearly 30% are incarcerated between ages 17 and 20 [27], and 17% of incarcerated adults report prior foster care involvement [7]. Particularly, the Midwest reports consistently high rates of foster care involvement and youth incarceration, motivating our regional focus. We

focus on Indiana and Illinois due to heightened system involvement and structural challenges affecting youth outcomes. For example, in Indiana, rates of youth incarceration and foster care placement exceed regional and national averages [17, 40], while Illinois ranks among the highest in the nation for children in foster care [13]. Both Indiana and Illinois also experience challenges with variation in resources and case management [28]. Only 34% of youth aged 14–21 receive transition supports in Indiana, compared to nearly 50% nationally [43]. In Illinois, these rates are nearly nonexistent, with only 5 % reported receiving transition services [42]. These services, such as vocational training and housing assistance, are critical for successful transitions to adulthood.

3 Methods

In this section, we provide an overview of our semi-structured interview study with details on the interview design. Then, we describe the recruitment methods and qualitative analysis.

3.1 Study Overview

We conducted a semi-structured interview study with 11 young adults formerly involved in foster care or the juvenile justice system to understand their experiences exiting these systems and how digital systems could help them access beneficial resources for more successful life outcomes. The interviews were conducted over Zoom and by phone to provide flexibility and accessibility for participants' locations and schedules. Before starting the interview, we shared an informed consent form with the participant to obtain their verbal consent and asked them to complete a brief demographics survey, including age, gender, and ethnicity. On average, the interviews lasted for 40 minutes. Participants were compensated with a \$30 Amazon eGift card upon the completion of the interview. Our semi-structured interview study was approved by the Institutional Review Board of our University.

3.2 Semi-structured Interview Design

We designed two semi-structured interview scripts for each participant group: 1) former youth who aged out of foster care and 2) former youth who transitioned out of the juvenile justice system. Both scripts aimed to gain insights into the experiences of youth in these systems, the resources they had or wished they had access to, and how technology could be leveraged to improve access to these resources. We also asked more tailored questions to each participant group. The interview scripts were organized as follows: 1) *Background, Experiences, and Challenges* (details on youth's involvement with in the system, what age and how many times they had entered the system, when did they transition out, their overall experience and challenges in the system, during transition, and after transitioning out), 2) *Resources During and After System Involvement* (which resources they had access to, what they lacked, what they wish they had had), and 3) *Technology-Based Solutions* (access to technology during system involvement, future digital solutions to provide better access to appropriate resources).

3.3 Participant Recruitment & Demographics

We reached out to foster care and juvenile justice organizations in Indiana and Illinois who disseminated our participation call

to the individuals they serve. Recruitment lasted from April 2025 to December 2025, yet our recruitment efforts are still ongoing to interview more formerly juvenile justice-involved youth. Our inclusion criteria were as follows: 1) at least 18 years of age, 2) have been involved in either foster care or the juvenile justice system in Indiana or Illinois, and 3) transitioned out of the system within the last five years. It is important to note that we encountered significant challenges when recruiting formerly justice-involved youth, possibly due to their involvement in the legal system and the accompanying fear of participation. Overall, we interviewed 9 young adults (7F, 2M) aged 18 to 23 who aged out of the foster care system within the past 5 years. Additionally, we interviewed 2 participants who were formerly involved with the juvenile justice system and were both 18 years old. We had 10 participants from Indiana and 1 from Illinois.

3.4 Qualitative Data Analysis

We conducted a reflexive thematic analysis [8] to systematically explore and interpret patterns within the data. The first author familiarized themselves with the data by iteratively reading the interview transcripts, taking notes, and open-coding. To deepen the analysis, the first, third, and last authors held regular reflexive discussions to review the initial codes and examine similarities and differences across participants. Through collaborative discussions, codes were iteratively grouped into potential themes. These themes underwent multiple rounds of review and refinement to ensure conceptual coherence, distinctiveness, and strong alignment with the participants' lived experiences. Finally, the first author synthesized the team's reflexive discussions to define and finalize the core themes.

3.5 Positionality

Our research team brings expertise in HCI, computer science, and social sciences, with two authors having professional experience in foster care advocacy and mass incarceration contexts, including juvenile justice. One of the authors has extensive expertise in studying the youth population and the safety of digital technology. Since we do not have lived experience within these systems, we entered this work aware of the power asymmetries between researchers and system-involved youth. We sought to mitigate these limitations through youth-centered methods and continuous reflexive practice. Still, we do not claim to speak for participants; rather, we offer a situated and partial account [25] informed by their expertise and our interpretive lens.

4 Findings

To understand how system-involved youth access resources during their transition to adulthood, we first highlight the existing assets and positive experiences reported by the participants. We then examine the challenges and gaps in accessing these resources, followed by insights into the support and resources youth desire for successful transitions. To illustrate our findings, we use quotes from participants, where each quote is identified by the participant's ID, the system involved (FC – Foster Care, JJ – Juvenile Justice), gender, and age.

4.1 Existing Assets

Despite navigating complex and fragmented systems, participants identified several assets that supported their transitions out of foster care and juvenile justice systems. Foster youth described being connected to **support networks** they otherwise would not have accessed, including independent living counselors, case managers, and foster parents. Several youth who aged out of foster care noted that aging out provided **access to resources not available through adoption**, including support for education, housing, and basic needs: *"There's so many benefits for us foster kids who age out that we can get our school paid for, have basic needs, they can help get an apartment"* (P1, FC, Female, 22 yrs. old). In contrast, juvenile justice-involved youth primarily relied on **informal supports** such as family members and faith leaders: *"My parents and pastor [were most helpful]"* (P11, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old). Across both systems, participants emphasized access to **education-related resources**. Foster youth highlighted grants that supported college attendance, while juvenile justice-involved youth described continued access to schooling and vocational classes during system involvement: *"And you can go to study classes, [...] barbershop classes. You go to different classes"* (P11, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old). Participants also emphasized the role of **nonprofit organizations** in providing support, rather than the system itself. All aged-out participants were connected with Foster Success, which prepared them for independent living through education, housing, and financial assistance: *"Foster Success is where you go if you need help. They have help with your car, school, mental health, taxes. They have guidance. They have love"* (P6, FC, Female, NA). Similarly, one juvenile justice-involved youth described the local VOICES chapter as instrumental in expanding access to opportunities: *"They [VOICES] helped me get to a lot of places, opened up a lot of doors for me"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old).

4.2 Constrained Assets

Despite the availability of some resources, most participants (FC: n=5; JJ: n=2) reported feeling **unprepared to transition out** of foster care or the juvenile justice system as they were not taught how to cope in real life: *"They [taught] absolutely nothing"* (P8, FC, Female, 21 yrs. old). Participants also described significant barriers in accessing available resources. Nearly all participants (FC: n=8; JJ: n=1) reported **limited communication** from staff, noting that resources were often not disclosed unless youth explicitly asked: *"A lot of the times they [staff] act like [no resources and support] exists until you bring it to their attention"* (P6, FC, Female, NA). This lack of guidance left many youth without support for independent living. Juvenile justice-involved youth further emphasized their **lack of preparation and support** for reentry, and the absence of assigned support personnel to assist with post-release resource connection, with one participant stating, *"No, there was actually no preparation. I got released and just went outside and went back into the world"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old). The other noted being released without resources and offered only warnings: *"[They just told] don't come back here. It's not the place you want to be"* (P11, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old).

Several aged-out youth described **rigid eligibility criteria** that created barriers to meeting basic needs. As one participant explained, access to food and housing assistance required extensive

documentation and the loss of essential assets, producing cycles of instability and forcing youth into impossible trade-offs which undermines both immediate survival and long-term goals such as employment and housing stability: *"A lot of times it's like you're jumping through hoops just to exist"* (P6, FC, Female, NA). Participants from both systems further identified **staff attitudes** as a barrier to accessing support, describing caseworkers and system staff as dismissive, disrespectful, or disengaged. Some foster youth reported experiencing fear-based interactions: *"They will also go to the point they'd scare you"* (P2, FC, Female, 21 yrs. old). Similarly, juvenile justice-involved youth described frequent power abuse by staff: *"I honestly feel like just how they treat you in there, like a lot of staff, since they got power, they can tell you what to do, they just kind of abuse it"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old). Such interactions contributed to feelings of powerlessness and lack of control. Aged-out foster youth also highlighted **systemic instability**, including frequent changes in placements, caseworkers, and counselors, which disrupted continuity of care and trust-building: *"Every single time you move to a different county, you get a different manager"* (P6, FC, Female, NA). Once youth aged out, these support networks were often severed entirely, leaving youth to navigate resources independently, often without centralized or coordinated access.

4.3 Envisioned Assets

Most participants expressed a strong desire for **more comprehensive programs and resources** to better prepare them for independent living, noting that currently *"you don't get taught how to live"* (P6, FC, Female, NA). Youth from both systems emphasized the need for practical life-skills programming, including support related to coping with everyday challenges, financial management, and employment. They also expressed interest in **relational, mentorship-based supports**: *"Just little programs that let you interact with good people, that got good mentors that treat you good, kind of Big Brother type people that can show you around"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old). Aged-out youth further identified needs in preparation for parenthood, basic self-care, and assistance with obtaining a driver's license: *"Help with getting driving hours would have really helped"* (P5, FC, Female, NA). Across both systems, participants emphasized a strong need for **accessible and ongoing mental health resources**, particularly as they navigated trauma, fear, and complex relationships: *"I would say programs about psychology[...] How to deal with emotions"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old).

In response to limited communication about available resources and the expectation that youth navigate systems independently after transitioning out, participants voiced a need for **up-to-date, searchable information** organized by need or location, as well as **testimonials** and recommendations for services such as mental health providers. Participants proposed having a **centralized space** to access resources and support relevant to their needs: *"I think it needs to be in one spot where you can go through and see the resources that you can get"* (P1, FC, Female, 22 yrs. old). One participant further emphasized the importance of visual guidance for navigating resources: *"I feel like a lot of it needs to be visual so you can see what you're looking at"* (P1, FC, Female, 22 yrs. old). Several participants also envisioned a system that should be youth-focused and function as a safe, welcoming space for connecting with resources, mentors,

counselors, and peers: *"Free floor with people that just makes the people feel comfortable"* (P10, JJ, Male, 18 yrs. old).

5 Discussion

Transitioning out of a foster care or juvenile justice system is a complex and overwhelming process for youth, as they are often expected to navigate adulthood with limited preparation and a sudden loss of formal support [10, 12]. Our findings suggest that existing systems do provide meaningful resources and support, particularly while youth remain formally involved, with participants noting various aspects that have previously been shown to positively influence transition outcomes, like access to strong social support networks [35] and education-focused resources [26]. Crucially, participants attributed their most effective support to external nonprofit organizations rather than the formal state system, aligning with prior studies that highlight the vital role of these decentralized resources [10, 23]. Despite this, most participants reported feeling unprepared to transition to independent living due to inadequate communication from staff, dismissive or negative staff attitudes, and abrupt termination of services at system exit.

Our results indicate that the overarching challenge for transitioning youth lies not in a lack of resources, but in the friction of how those resources are distributed and organized. Although online platforms provide essential avenues for support, systemic policies actively inhibit youth's digital access prior to their transition. For instance, foster youth are often restricted from using smart devices to mitigate online risks [4, 5], while technology and online access have been even more tightly controlled and restricted for youth in the juvenile justice system. With increasing evidence demonstrating the critical role of digital access in cultivating support networks and navigating independent living [15, 16], there has been a growing shift toward technology-based interventions and solutions in both the foster care and juvenile justice systems [14, 48]. The importance of this shift is underscored by recent literature, showing that access to technology-based behavioral health services [44, 45] and digital reentry interventions in the juvenile justice system not only facilitate better long-term life outcomes but also play a vital role in significantly reducing youth recidivism [34].

5.1 Design Implications for Socio-Technical Support Systems

To bridge this gap in resource accessibility for system-involved youth, HCI researchers must design **digital, centralized hubs grounded in trauma-informed principles** [30, 50] that are tailored to the needs of system-involved youth and that support them in easily navigating critical resources. Rather than forcing youth to navigate a fragmented web of services, these tailored hubs would centralize comprehensive support, including system policies, educational resources, housing assistance, and mental health services. Crucially, these platforms must be **dynamic**, incorporating automated resource aggregation and updating tools that continuously monitor external data sources for changes in policies, financial aid eligibility, and available services, ensuring that information within the hub remains current and reliable. Furthermore, to facilitate effective navigation and reduce cognitive overload, these hubs should integrate **smart search functionality** capable of summarizing

highly relevant resources and enabling granular filtering based on specific user needs, eligibility constraints, and geographic location.

Beyond listing resources, the platform can also facilitate **relational and peer-based support** by enabling live chats with professionals (e.g., counselors) and providing **anonymous spaces** for youth to connect with one another and share experiences. Given the importance youth place on peer trust, incorporating **testimonials** and shared experiences related to services and providers is essential. Finally, findings indicate a strong need for visual guidance; therefore, both navigation and resource content could be presented using **clear visual structures and accessible multi-media formats**. This is supported by previous scholarship showing that visual representations provide a better understanding of the content, organizations, and learning outcomes [39].

6 Limitations and Future Research

While this study provides insights into the resource and support needs of system-involved youth, we acknowledge several limitations and avenues for future research. First, the study was conducted in the Midwest, primarily in Indiana, which may limit the transferability of findings to other states or regions with different foster care and juvenile justice structures. Future work could examine whether similar patterns emerge in other geographic and policy contexts. The recruitment process presented significant challenges, particularly in reaching justice-involved youth. Despite multiple outreach strategies and promising initial connections, recruiting participants from this population was difficult; this was largely due to structural barriers that prevent direct contact with formerly justice-involved individuals, requiring recruitment through justice departments and extended referral chains. Additionally, trauma and fear associated with prior justice involvement may have reduced willingness to participate. Future research can explore alternative, trauma-informed recruitment approaches and partnerships to better engage this population. We continue recruitment efforts across both populations to expand the dataset, validate initial findings, and generate deeper insights. Future phases of our research will engage system-involved youth as co-designers, ensuring that proposed solutions are grounded in their lived experiences and better aligned with their needs.

7 Conclusion

This study investigated the lived experiences of system-involved youth regarding their resource access during and after their transition out of the system. Through our analysis, we demonstrate that youth are navigating a landscape where resources are present but scattered, poorly communicated, and frequently inaccessible after system exit. Thus, we urge HCI researchers to expand their focus beyond social support and design for informational continuity, allowing system-involved youth to navigate independence with confidence, clarity, and agency.

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